Listening while taking notes

Practical guide for students | D05-ST

Your notes should help you understand and revisit the lesson. Focus on recording the main ideas and their connections, rather than writing down everything the teacher says.

1. Prepare a simple structure

If slides or an outline are available, preview them before class. Use the headings to organise your notes and leave space for explanations, examples and questions.

2. Listen for meaning before writing

Listen long enough to understand the point, then record it briefly. If you try to copy every sentence, you may miss the next part of the explanation.

When your teacher explains a diagram or worked example, watch and listen first. Add notes at a suitable pause.

3. Record key ideas and relationships

Include important concepts, definitions, stages, causes, contrasts and conclusions. Add an example when it helps explain the idea.

Use short phrases, familiar abbreviations and symbols that you will understand later. Keep essential subject terms accurate.

4. Add to the materials provided

If you have the slides or a handout, record what the spoken explanation adds. Avoid copying information already available unless doing so helps you understand it.

Clearly connect each note to the relevant slide, heading or diagram.

5. Mark gaps and keep following

Leave a space or add a question mark when you miss something. Rejoin the explanation rather than trying to reconstruct everything immediately.

Ask for clarification at an appropriate pause.

6. Review and use your notes

Soon after class:

- Explain the main ideas without looking at your notes.
- Check your explanation against your notes and course materials.
- Correct errors and fill important gaps.
- Compare uncertain points with a classmate or ask your teacher.
- Turn key ideas into questions you can answer during revision.

You can use different languages in personal notes if helpful, while keeping the English subject terms you need for your course.

Example

What the teacher says "Revenue increased this month, but profit fell. This happened because ingredient and staffing costs increased by more than revenue."

Possible notes

Revenue ↑, but profit ↓
Reason: ingredient + staffing costs ↑ more than revenue
Key point: higher revenue ≠ higher profit

Review question How can profit fall when revenue increases?

Check your notes

- I have recorded the main ideas.
- I can follow the relationships between them.
- My abbreviations and symbols make sense to me.
- I have marked anything that needs checking.
- I use my notes to explain and recall ideas, rather than only rereading them.

If taking notes regularly prevents you from following: show your teacher an example of your notes and explain the difficulty. Ask about available outlines, accessible materials or relevant study support. If you want to record a lesson, check permission and institutional rules first.

Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). Note-taking in classes and lectures. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports recognising important points through introductions, conclusions, emphasis, linking expressions and repetition, and reviewing notes after class. See "In class time", "Linking expressions" and "After class".

University of Reading. (2026). Getting the most from your lectures. Open resource

Supports previewing materials, prioritising understanding over transcription, using abbreviations and keywords, annotating handouts, leaving gaps, recalling ideas without notes and checking understanding with peers. See "Preparing for your lectures", "Active listening and note-making" and "Reviewing and retaining information".